



New hope: While New Zealand has qualified for the World Cup twice before, they've never gone past the group stage — something Sarpreet believes can change now. GETTY IMAGES

Sarpreet himself is more than grateful to be part of the New Zealand set-up. While there were never many players of Indian origin in New Zealand's football scene, he's never felt anything but included. "I never felt like an underdog in the team. If anything, I think I have enough experience and I've played a lot of good games for New Zealand, and people understand what I bring to the national team," he says.

Big ambitions

While New Zealand has qualified for the World Cup twice before, they've never gone past the group stage — something Sarpreet believes can change now.

"Our goal is to get out of the group stage and I don't think we have to change too much. There's a difference between the side we have now and the one we had in 2010. So

many of our players are playing in Europe, while in the past I think some players weren't even completely professional. The standards have all been raised a lot. Obviously, you need a bit of luck in the draw and it won't be easy, but I do think we are capable," he says.

Sarpreet says qualification is significant not just for himself but for the country's football programme. "We've qualified for the World Cup both as a team and me individually, but I don't want to be at the World Cup just to participate. We want to do well. I want to do well because it's a great opportunity to show what I'm capable of. But I also want more people to see and talk about our team because that will help other players as well," he says.

Should he eventually compete next year, Sarpreet knows there will be many eyes on him. He says his

social media inbox has already been flooded with Indians offering support. "I always knew that I was going to get a little bit more attention because of my roots. I've always had a bit of a following because of my journey to Bayern. And then I think in the last couple of years, where I haven't done as well, it maybe veered off a little bit — but then as soon as we qualified for the World Cup, it has all come back again. Sometimes when I see the messages, I feel quite privileged and motivated as well because that's what drives me to want to do more. I know there haven't been too many players of Indian origin who've played at World Cups. It's really a proud feeling for me. I'm aware of what I carry with me in achieving these things. That's what really drives me to try and go even further and make everyone proud," he says.